

Pahankanuwa Sermon #13

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

Manopubbaṅgamā dhammā, manoseṭṭhā manomayā; Manasā ce pasannena, bhāsati vā karoti vā; Tato naṃ sukhamanveti, chāyāva anapāyini.

From:

Verse 2 from the Yamakavagga (Chapter of Pairs) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

The very appearance of a Buddha in the world is an event that demonstrates the miraculous power within the mind. The supreme level of development, purity, and clarity of the mind can be witnessed by us in a *Tathāgata*, a fully Awakened One. Moreover, such a Buddha appears in the world and expounds the Dhamma to show us the path to develop, purify, and clarify our minds. In this liberation from Saṃsāra, this grave task of freeing ourselves from the *Dukkha* (suffering) of Saṃsāra, in this great undertaking, it is our mind that is fundamental. It is by utilizing this mind—and not by any other scientific methods—that we can escape from Saṃsāra. This mind of ours contracts or expands, becomes small or large; these changes occur according to the object the mind takes. The Buddha has demonstrated this with examples on many occasions. If our mind takes a small object, the mind becomes small; if it takes a large object, it becomes large. Now, from the background story of the verse we have chosen as our theme, we can gain a good understanding of the functioning of this mind.

There lived in Sāvattihī a very wealthy but extremely miserly Brahmin. Since this Brahmin had never given anything to anyone, based on that behavior, society gave him a nickname, branding him "Adinnapubbaka" (Never-giver). The Sinhala

meaning of the word *Adinnapubbaka* is "one who has never given before." He got the name "Never-giver"—this Brahmin. This was probably because people in those days, just like today, were very clever at giving nicknames. Now, this Brahmin had an only son, who was very pleasant and dear. He loved his son very much, as he was his only child. But he loved his wealth even more. Therefore, when it came to making ear-ornaments for his son according to the custom of that society, this Brahmin thought, "If I summon a goldsmith now, my wealth will be destroyed for this task. Therefore, I must make the ear-ornaments myself." He flattened two small pieces of gold and hung them on the child's ears. Thus, the child was also given a nickname by society according to the ornament hung on his ears: "Maṭṭakuṇḍalī" (Polished Earring), because he wore ear-ornaments made of flattened, plain gold.

And so, perhaps because this child lived his life in such a miserable manner, by the time he was about sixteen years old, he contracted jaundice—a severe case of jaundice. The mother Brahmin lady told the Brahmin to go and bring a physician. The Brahmin replied, "Can't you see how my wealth will be ruined if I bring a physician?" Saying so, what he did instead was go to physicians and, by speaking in a beating-around-the-bush manner, tried to find out the prescriptions from them. He asked, "What is the medicine given for such-and-such an illness?" Those who are physicians also often give casual remedies to casual inquiries. Thus, the physicians casually told him that the bark of such-and-such trees is good for this kind of disease. This Brahmin came home, gathered those barks, and tried to perform home remedies. These home remedies did not succeed. The child's condition became critical, worsened, and reached a state where it seemed incurable. Finally, when there was absolutely no other way, the Brahmin went and brought a physician. The moment the physician looked at him, he realized, "If I undertake to treat this patient, my reputation will be ruined." Therefore, saying, "I have other work to attend to, call another physician," he quietly slipped away.

Then the Brahmin understood that the child was now on the verge of death. Next, he thought, "When this son dies, those who come to the funeral house will see the wealth inside my home." Thinking so, he laid the dying child on the outer veranda, the porch. On that very day, the Buddha, as was his daily custom, arose in the early dawn and entered the attainment of great compassion (*mahākaruṇā-samāpatti*) to survey the world, and Maṭṭakuṇḍalī appeared in his Buddha-eye. That knowledge of the attainment of great compassion is a wonderful, sublime knowledge unique only to a Buddha. It is a wondrous kind of attainment that arises in a Buddha, supported by the wisdom and great compassion developed throughout the entire saṃsāric journey. When the Buddha arises from that attainment and surveys the world, what usually appears are those who have

performed various meritorious deeds under past Buddhas, which have now ripened. Thus, Maṭṭakuṇḍalī, who was preparing to end his life in this miserable manner, appeared in the Buddha's eye.

So, out of great compassion, the Buddha walked for alms that day to the street where the Brahmin's house was located, accompanied by the community of bhikkhus. When he arrived exactly in front of the house, the Buddha saw the child lying down, facing the interior of the house—that is, facing the wall. Seeing this, the Buddha, in order to draw the child's attention, emitted a ray of Buddha-light, a single Buddha-ray, in that direction. When the light fell upon the wall, the child turned and looked. Looking, and upon seeing the physical form of the Buddha, he felt a great joyous confidence and faith (*saddhā*), thinking, "Alas! Because of my foolish father, I never got the opportunity to see such a Buddha, to attend on him, to listen to the Dhamma, or to offer alms." Then he tried to raise his two hands to worship with palms joined over his head. However, due to his weak state, he could only bring his fingers together. Next, he thought, "All I can do now is clarify my mind," and with his entire heart, without any ordinary doubts, dedicating his whole mind, he clarified his mind towards the Buddha. As he lay there gazing at the Buddha, the Buddha thought, "This merit is sufficient for him," and departed from there. Just as the Buddha went out of sight—beyond the range of visibility—this child Maṭṭakuṇḍalī passed away. Having died with that very clarified mind, he was reborn as a *devaputta* (divine son) adorned with golden ornaments in a thirty-league golden mansion in the Tāvātimsa heaven.

Having been born thus, he then looked to see, "How did I obtain this celestial fortune?" All such deities contemplate in this manner, reflecting on how they attained their present state. Then he saw the condition of his father, the Brahmin. After cremating the corpse, the Brahmin went to the cemetery every day and wept, crying, "Where is my only son? Where is my only son?" The *devaputta* Maṭṭakuṇḍalī saw this behavior of the Brahmin. Seeing this, he thought of teaching him a lesson. He went to the cemetery appearing in the form of Maṭṭakuṇḍalī, but as a youth adorned with golden ornaments, and began to weep. When the Brahmin saw this *devaputta*—perhaps because he had the likeness of his own child, feeling a certain special affection—he asked, "Why are you crying?" The youth replied, "I have obtained a golden carriage frame. But because I cannot find suitable wheels for it, I am planning to die of grief," implying he would commit suicide. Then the Brahmin said, "If you want, I will have wheels made for you from gold, silver, or brass, just as you wish." When he said this, the *devaputta* said, "I have no use for other wheels; I want the sun and the moon." Then the Brahmin said, "You foolish boy, why do you wish for something that cannot be obtained in this way?" Then the *devaputta* replied, "I am wishing for

the sun and the moon, which are visible. You are wishing for a deceased son, wishing for someone who can no longer be seen. Out of the two of us, who is the bigger fool?" When he asked this, the Brahmin's wisdom dawned. He dispelled his grief. Dispelling it, and thanking the *devaputta* Maṭṭakuṇḍalī, he declared, "I have quenched my grief." He then asked, "Who are you?" The *devaputta* replied, "I am your son. By clarifying my mind in this manner in my final moment, as the result of a certain wholesome thought, I have attained such a birth."

Then the Brahmin said, "I never saw you giving alms, keeping precepts, or listening to the Dhamma, nor performing any meritorious deeds. How did you obtain this state?" Then the *devaputta* Maṭṭakuṇḍalī declared, "When the Buddha arrived here, I clarified my mind. As a result of that serene mind, that clarified mind, I received this kind of state." Then he advised the Brahmin, "You too, go for refuge to the Triple Gem and undertake the five precepts. See the Buddha, give alms, listen to the Dhamma, and accumulate merit in that way." Having said this, the *devaputta* Maṭṭakuṇḍalī vanished.

The Brahmin too went to see the Buddha, invited him for an almsgiving, and prepared alms at his home. The Buddha and the community of bhikkhus arrived for the alms. Even those with wrong views assembled in large numbers at the Brahmin's house. On this occasion, after presenting the alms and after the meal was finished, the Brahmin questioned the Buddha, "Without giving alms, keeping precepts, or listening to the Dhamma, is it possible to obtain celestial fortune merely by clarifying the mind towards you?" Then the Buddha declared, "Why, Brahmin, did your own son not tell you this very thing?" When the Buddha expressed it in this way, some in the crowd developed doubts. "How can one obtain such great fortune merely by clarifying the mind?" The Buddha then willed that the *devaputta* Maṭṭakuṇḍalī arrive there along with his celestial mansion. Accordingly, the *devaputta* arrived at that place together with his mansion, descended from it, paid homage to the Buddha, and stood to one side. Then, the Buddha removed the doubts of the crowd by asking the *devaputta* himself about the deed he had performed, posing questions and receiving answers. At that point, the crowd developed great clarity of mind. "How miraculous are the qualities of the Buddha! Merely by clarifying the mind towards a Buddha, such great fortune can be obtained!"—thus they developed immense joyous confidence and faith (*saddhā*). In that manner, the Buddha, to clarify this matter, delivered a highly valuable Dhamma message to the world based on this incident, using the verse we mentioned earlier:

'Mano pubbaṅgamā dhammā — manoseṭṭhā manomayā

Manasā ce pasannena — bhāsatī vā karoti vā

Tato nam sukham-anveti — chāyā va anapāyini'

That means, "*Mano pubbaṅgamā dhammā — manoseṭṭhā manomayā*." Now, the word *dhammā* here is generally explained as the mental phenomena that arise in the mind, such as *vedanā* (feeling), perception, and intention. Mind precedes all of them; the mind is prior to them, and the mind is supreme to them. The mind is supreme to them. They are made of mind, fashioned by mind. Because this is so, "*manasā ce pasannena — bhāsatī vā karoti vā*," if with a highly clarified mind, with a certain clarified mind, one speaks or acts, "*tato nam sukham-anveti — chāyā va anapāyini*," then, behind that person—the person who did that deed—its results, its pleasant results, follow him like his own shadow that never departs; thus the Buddha declared. The meaning within this verse is so deep that it is said that upon hearing this verse, not only the *devaputta* Maṭṭakuṇḍalī but even the Brahmin Adinnapubbaka attained the fruit of Stream-entry (*sotāpatti-phala*). That is to say, perhaps their past matured merits surfaced upon hearing that verse. Not only that, it is said that eighty-four thousand living beings realized the Dhamma. Those thousands mentioned there include deities as well. When we preach a sermon, it is not only these visible humans, but various classes of deities, non-human spirits (*bhūtas*), and other beings who wish to escape the *Dukkha* of Saṃsāra and have faith in the Triple Gem, who listen to it. Especially when the Buddha preaches the Dhamma, everyone listens to it. That is why those thousands are mentioned as those who reaped the benefits.

Therefore, we must reflect on this verse. Moreover, we must bring close to our lives the example that can be taken from the background story of this verse. From every Dhamma talk, from every verse, we must gather some example, some Dhamma message for our lives. Listening to the Dhamma is not something where merit is accumulated merely by the act of hearing. Therefore, we can understand this story as an extremely good illustration of how the mind is chief in everything. When we look at the life led by Adinnapubbaka, that fact becomes clear to us. No matter how much wealth this Brahmin had, he was poor in mind. From this we can see that being rich or poor is not something that happens through wealth alone. Even if one has vast wealth, if one is miserly, that person is always poor in mind. "This is not enough," or "I am still poor, I have not yet become truly rich," is what he thinks due to his miserliness. Thus, because of this, although the Brahmin Adinnapubbaka had so much wealth, he was poor in mind—a very destitute person. Furthermore, the darkness and narrowness of a miserly mind was visible in what the Brahmin did and said. From this we see that this mind itself is chief in everything. Next, it is the same with the darkening of a mind and

then its illumination. This is something that must be contemplated very deeply. The Buddha has declared that there is a class of dark phenomena, and likewise, there is a class of light phenomena, illuminating phenomena.

"*Kaṇhaṃ dhammaṃ vippahāya, sukkaṃ bhāvētha paṇḍito*," the Buddha has declared. 'The wise person, abandoning dark phenomena, should develop bright phenomena.' Dark phenomena, meaning greed, hatred, and delusion—these are black/dark phenomena. Non-greed, non-hatred, and non-delusion are white/bright phenomena. These are illuminating phenomena, called *sukka-dhamma*. In this way, we see that the Brahmin had his mind darkened due to dark phenomena. Next, when we think of the other side, the young child Maṭṭakuṇḍalī was not as rich as the Brahmin. At the moment of death, he was extremely poor and helpless, possessing only the two pieces of gold hanging from his ears. But how did he obtain such a celestial rebirth? He became rich in mind. He made his mind rich. How did he make his mind rich? We must contemplate this matter well. He made his mind rich by taking as his mind's object the most sublime, supreme gem in the world. The Buddha himself has declared that among all the gems in the world, the Buddha-gem is supreme and foremost. This is mentioned in the Ratana Sutta:

'Yaṅkiñci vittaṃ idha vā huraṃ vā,

Saggesu vā yaṃ ratanaṃ paṇītaṃ,

Na no samaṃ atthi Tathāgatena...'

Thus it is mentioned. Whatever wealth or gem there is in the world—in this world or in another world, or even in the celestial realms—none of those gems is as valuable as the Buddha-gem, the *Tathāgata*. Likewise:

'Yaṅkiñci ratanaṃ loke,

Vijjati vividhā puthu,

Ratanaṃ Buddhasamaṃ natthi,

Tasmā sotthī bhavantu te.'

There are such verses of blessing. Whatever diverse gems exist in the world, there is no gem equal to the Buddha-gem. Not only that, the Buddha himself had to declare—since the world did not recognize the *Tathāgata*—that a *Tathāgata*, fully Awakened One, is the foremost individual in the world. In the Aggappasāda Sutta, the Buddha declared:

'Yāvatā, bhikkhave, sattā apadā vā dvipadā vā catuppadā vā bahuppadā vā rūpino vā arūpino vā saññino vā asaññino vā nevasaññināsaññino vā, Tathāgato tesam aggam akkhāyati araham sammāsambuddho. Ye, bhikkhave, Budde pasannā, agge te pasannā; agge kho pana pasannānam aggo vipāko hoti.'

"Bhikkhus, to whatever extent there are beings—whether footless, two-footed, four-footed, many-footed, with form, formless, percipient, non-percipient, or neither-percipient-nor-non-percipient—the *Tathāgata*, the Arahant, the fully Awakened One, is declared to be the foremost among them. Bhikkhus, those who have clarified confidence in the Buddha, have clarified confidence in the foremost; and for those who have clarified confidence in the foremost, the result is foremost." In this manner, the Buddha declared in the Aggappasāda Sutta. From this, we see how rich in benefits is the act of clarifying the mind toward the Buddha.

Sometimes we might wonder, "How can one obtain such vast fortune merely by clarifying the mind for a single moment?" Especially in this era, this is a time when the mind goes more towards external things. The world speaks highly of their bigness, vastness, and wondrous nature. People harbor doubts about the power of this invisible mind, the power that can be generated in the mind even in a single moment. They ask, "How can one obtain such a great fortune by doing just this much?" But we must consider that the activity of this mind is extremely instantaneous, extremely rapid. Within this rapidly functioning mind, a power that brings massive benefits can be generated in a single moment. Now here, Maṭṭakuṇḍalī clarified his mind towards the Buddha for just a brief moment, or a short period of time. Even that much is not required. If, for a very brief moment, like a split second, a snap of the fingers, some clarity, an opening occurs in the mind, from that itself, an immensely valuable benefit can be reaped. Now, you all know—let us think of a dark night of dense darkness. Let us think of a night with heavy rain and storms, like we have these days, a night with darkness so thick it cannot be pierced. If lightning flashes for a single moment on such a night, in that extremely brief instant, everything around becomes clearly visible. In the same way, an opening occurs in the mind based on the object of clarity it takes, based on the object of clarifying the mind. In such a dark night, much work can be accomplished by the flash of lightning that appears for a brief moment. There are those in the past who have worked in this manner. There are stories from the past (it is mentioned like this) where archers in those days, like marksmen today, in order to show their skill and win prizes, or to set records, would stand ready with their arrow on a dark night, waiting for the moment of a lightning flash. Far away, an extremely fine hair taken from a horse's tail is hung. Now, what is the feat to be performed? This horsehair must be split with that arrow. He stands ready for this. The moment the lightning flashes, he shoots. If this is done

correctly, then that person is a skilled archer. This is told as a metaphor—he performed such a feat within a single instant.

Now, you have heard how our Buddhist poets have declared:

"To shoot a horsehair from afar in the dark,

If the lightning's flash is missed, one fails the mark;

When this body, like lightning, is obtained here,

If one does not secure heaven and release, future failure is near."

— *Lōvāda Saṅgarāva*, verse 25.

In that moment of shooting a horsehair in the dark, if it is done correctly, then one can reap its benefits. Now, many people these days talk about "the moment." They say we must work instantaneously in this life. We are talking about the moments within this life. But the Buddha declares that this entire human existence of ours is but a single instant, a single moment. He declares this with supporting reasons. To us, this seems like a long time. But when this human life, a lifespan of less than a hundred years, is compared and contrasted with the Brahma existences that last for aeons, this is like a single instant. This life, which we think of as so large, spending a few years in this immensely long saṃsāric journey, is in reality a single instant. Therefore, the Buddha refers to this entire human life as a single instant.

Now, the Buddha specifically demonstrates that the human existence obtained during the period of a Buddha's appearance is not merely an instant, but an opportune moment (*kṣaṇa-sampatti*). He describes it as a highly rare opportunity, a rare instant—an opportune moment. If, during the period of a Buddha's appearance, someone is born in a region where they can hear the Dhamma with the capacity of understanding and wisdom to practice the Dhamma, that is called the opportune moment (*kṣaṇa-sampatti*). An extremely valuable instant. It is that very instant the poet has used as a metaphor. When he says, "When this body, like lightning, is obtained here," he is referring to this human existence. This human body itself is just like a flash of lightning. This body exists, this existence lasts, for such a brief moment, like a flash of lightning. Therefore, as Buddhists, we must understand this instant as the entirety of human life.

If we reflect in this way, generating wholesome thoughts and performing meritorious deeds is not something to be put off until the final moment, as Maṭṭakuṇḍalī did. One should not harbor such wrong views as thinking, "We can

go to heaven if we do this only at the moment of death." Nowadays, some people think in that manner. They accumulate wealth through unlawful means, committing various crimes, and then expect to invite a member of the Saṅgha at the last moment to listen to a little Dhamma and go to heaven. Although Maṭṭakuṇḍalī was able to do so because he was one who had developed and fulfilled the *paramis* under past Buddhas, everything does not succeed by that alone. Indeed, the *devaputta* Maṭṭakuṇḍalī obtained such a state due to a certain natural law, a deep aspect regarding kamma. For, beings are born in various places according to their kamma. However, the kamma generated according to the sign (*nimitta*) that appears at the moment of death, called the *āsanna-kamma* (near-death kamma), is highly powerful. That is why the Buddha walked there to give Maṭṭakuṇḍalī an opportunity to purify his near-death mind and perform a wholesome deed. But not everyone can perform that feat. Sometimes, due to the sins committed during one's lifetime, a different sign appears, and one is forced to take birth in a bad destination. That archer split the horsehair in that manner because he had put in effort and training for a long time. It is not something that can be done all of a sudden.

So, what we have to understand here is that we must not wait until the near-death moment or old age. Thinking of the entirety of life as a single instant, we must constantly strive to generate within ourselves this very mind—a serene mind, a clarified mind, a pure mind, an illuminated mind. For, if those dark phenomena present themselves, we fall into darkness. If we bring forward bright phenomena, we take birth in a good destination. Not only that, we can gradually draw closer to Nibbāna (extinguishment). Nibbāna means freeing the mind from these dark phenomena of greed, hatred, and delusion.

From this, we can understand the value of this instant and that this is something that must be constantly practiced and trained. Just as that archer exerts effort, a Buddhist must always keep watch over the mind. One must examine whether the phenomena arising in this mind are things that lead to the mind's clarity or things that agitate it. Now, regarding the word clarity—here, *pasanna* means clarified. What is mentioned here regarding the *devaputta* Maṭṭakuṇḍalī is the benefit of that clarified mind. The value of clarity can be understood: when water flows after a rain, filled with mud and flowing in an extremely unpleasant manner, what is the state of our mind when we see it? Next, when we look at beautifully clear water, clarified water, our mind becomes clear and peaceful. In the same way, when we bring a sublime object, a supreme object like the Buddha, into our mind, when we bring it close to our mind, our mind becomes clarified. Therefore, the word *pasāda* (clarity/joyous confidence) goes hand-in-hand with faith (*saddhā*). It is said, *saddhā-pasāda* (faith and clarity). With faith, clarity follows. From this, we see that faith (*saddhā*) in the Triple Gem is an extremely

important thing. A mind without faith in the Triple Gem remains darkened by skeptical doubt (*vicikicchā*), hesitation, and uncertainty. Their minds are just like agitated water, like muddy water. But if someone develops faith in the Buddha, a great clarity arises in the mind along with it. This is realized by you, devout friends, even in your day-to-day lives.

That *devaputta* Maṭṭakuṇḍalī clarified his mind by seeing the physical form, the body, of the Buddha. Although we do not get to see that physical body of the Buddha now, we can see the Dhamma-body (*Dhammakāya*). We can see the body of the Buddha's virtues. Therefore, from this, what we must specifically consider is the value of the meditation on the recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati bhāvanā*). Contemplating the virtues of the Buddha. Through the virtues of the Buddha, we can see the Buddha. If we contemplate the nine-fold virtues of the Buddha, direct our mind to those virtues like *Arahaṃ*, bring to the surface a virtue that suits our mind, and train ourselves to constantly bring to the mind a phrase like "Arahaṃ, Arahaṃ, Arahaṃ" or "Buddho," "Sammā Sambuddho," like a meditation, then through that, we can obtain great joyous confidence and an illumination for our daily activities. Now, as expressed in that verse, if with a clarified mind, a serene mind, "*bhāsatī vā karoti vā*," someone utters a word or performs an action, its pleasant results follow behind him like his shadow. It is this mind of ours that provides illumination to the words we use and the actions we perform. When this mind is clarified, a great light arises in the mind, like a flash of lightning on a pitch-black night.

Therefore, to constantly bring to the mind the clarity towards the Triple Gem, one must train in contemplating the Buddha's virtues as *Buddhānussati* meditation. While traveling in a vehicle, while in a city—now there is no telling when the time will come. We must think of every moment now as the near-death moment. Especially when thinking about the present times, some people think of the near-death moment as being eighty or ninety years old, surrounded by children and grandchildren; that is how they imagine the near-death moment. Today, we must step onto the road thinking we are in a near-death situation. Such is the state of affairs. Because of that, we must be much more watchful over the mind. If, in a bad moment, when the mind is spoiled, darkened, or muddled, we pass away—if we die suddenly—where will we go and be born? In a dark place. Either in hell, or in the realm of hungry ghosts (*petas*), or the demon realm. We said, didn't we, that there are two groups called dark phenomena and bright phenomena. There are two factions in this mind. Whatever factions exist in the world, we must be concerned about the factions in this mind, because it is our mind that we carry wherever we go. Therefore, the dark faction in this mind consists of greed, hatred, and delusion. These are the three that appear prominently in this dark faction: greed, hatred, and delusion. There are many

auxiliary phenomena related to them. Next, the bright phenomena that aid in reaching Nibbāna are non-greed, non-hatred, and non-delusion. At first glance, there seems to be nothing here when we say "non-greed"; what is this non-greed? It is sometimes difficult to conceptualize. Non-greed means abstaining from greed. Abstaining from greed might sometimes be thought of as a trivial thing. This is not a trivial thing. This is called a *virati-cetasika* (mental factor of abstinence), the thought of abstaining.

This thought regarding abstinence is a very powerful thing. Now, something that mainly supports this is virtue (*sīla*), the undertaking of precepts. Taking precepts. At this moment, when you all, to abstain from killing living beings—*veramaṇī*—indeed, when taking precepts, the word *veramaṇī* must be pronounced well. "*Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi*," I undertake the training rule to abstain from taking life, from killing living beings. This is a certain promise made to oneself, accepting and putting it into practice. Even though it is uttered in front of the Saṅgha, this is in fact a promise made to oneself. Or rather, one instills in one's mind, "I will spend this day in this manner, based on the practice." Then, for a person who has made up their mind thus, let us say next, an opportunity arises—either for food, for pleasure, or to settle a grudge—where they feel like killing someone or an animal. The moment that thought arises, one is able to push it aside through this very non-hatred (*adosa*). One brings up loving-kindness, compassion, kindness, non-harming, and recalling the virtue one has undertaken, one abstains from it. To take this as an example: that moment is an extremely valuable moment. The power of being able to detach the mind. That is what is called a *virati-cetasika*. It is called *sampatta-virati* (abstinence upon encountering an opportunity). That means the opportunity to commit a sinful act has come. But one does not do it. One withdraws one's hand. Now, to commit a theft—one knows it is a highly valuable object belonging to another. It lies in front, there is no one around. All one has to do is look around, and then slowly stretch out the hand in that direction. But the mind says at that moment, "Do not do that." Why does it think so? Precisely because of having undertaken that virtue: "*Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi*." Following this, we see that taking precepts is not a trivial matter. It is not just a mere ritual—nowadays, at every meeting or festival, a taking of precepts is recited to show that one is Buddhist. But when one reflects on its depth, how powerful and important is it! It is the first step in our life. In this manner—it is called "by way of substitution of opposites" (*tadaṅga-vasena*)—the mind is distanced from the defilements. Inserting a wholesome thought for that particular moment, the unwholesome thought is pushed away. For this, one must also accumulate wholesome thoughts within oneself. Loving-kindness must be developed to abandon hatred. To abandon greed, generosity—giving, charity,

the quality of renunciation—must be developed. To abandon delusion, understanding, wisdom, thinking, thinking wisely, contemplation—wise contemplation to understand the true nature of things—must be used as aids. Therefore, the moment non-greed, non-hatred, and non-delusion are mentioned, it seems as if there is nothing there. But if we analyze and contemplate, what is being spoken of here is the power to subdue and drive back those unwholesome phenomena that come from outside, arriving as guests, arriving as enemies. This is what is meant by abstinence (*virati*).

This is not a feat that can be done all of a sudden. Therefore, we must constantly develop that mind by way of meditation. The Buddha too, when speaking of meditation, mentions three words: "*āsevati, bhāveti, bahulīkaroti*." Frequently associating with some wholesome object. Let us say, if it is *Buddhānussati*, one frequently associates with a word like "Araham, Araham, Araham" or "Buddho" like a friend in one's home, constantly bringing it up and living with it—this is *āsevati* (associating). *Bhāveti* means developing it. Saying it a second time, a greater strength comes to the mind than the first time. Saying that word 'Buddha' ten times, a thousand times, millions and billions of times, the faith (*saddhā*) towards the Triple Gem develops more and more. This is not merely reciting it as a mantra. The heart must also function alongside it. A clarity must arise in the heart. It is the same with other meditations: if one is developing loving-kindness, words like 'may all beings be well and happy'—in that manner, depending on the meditation object one has chosen, one must constantly associate with it. One must strive to develop the mind through that—meditation (*bhāvanā*).

Next, there is the word *bahulī-kamma* — *bahulīkaroti*, making much of it, doing it abundantly. That means not just for a day or two, or for an hour or half an hour, but abundantly. One must exert effort oneself. No matter how much work one has in daily life, if someone has understood the value of their mind—we labor so much for this body. To nourish this body, to bathe and wash it, to adorn it, all of this. This 'vile, decaying body that will be left behind.' How much do we care for it? Yet, we do not think about the value of the mind even for a very brief moment of the day. It is this mind that assists us in escaping from Saṃsāra, and also in securing a happy destination. If one thinks in this way, then one becomes interested in meditation. In the manner described as *āsevati, bhāveti, bahulīkaroti*, one must constantly bring some wholesome object to the mind and live with it. Even though it might seem difficult and troublesome at the beginning, once it becomes a habit, one can do it effortlessly, without exertion—almost automatically. Now, when wearing a pair of spectacles for the first time, it is a great nuisance. But after a few days, one can work very easily with those spectacles. After some time, one might even look for the spectacles while wearing

them on one's face. Why is this? Because to that extent, those spectacles have become a part of one's body.

The meditation object is also like that. Then, for the person who has developed *Buddhānussati*, when a danger arises—nowadays, people sometimes say "Budu Amme" (Oh, Buddha Mother). According to past custom, the word 'Budu' (Buddha) has become part of our society. But that is not just an automatic exclamation when pain arises. With the entire mind—Maṭṭakuṇḍalī obtained that state by clarifying his mind with his entire mind, not by saying it merely as a custom or a mantra. We must contemplate in that manner. One must think of the maximum benefit one can extract from every story and strive to reap it. One must strive to reap the maximum benefit. Now, according to the things stated in this verse, we see that our mind is chief in the words we use and the actions we perform, in everything. That is the uniqueness of the Buddha's Dhamma. In this era, there are various scientific ways of thinking. They are mostly structured according to wrong views. This is because they give priority to physical things, to external things. Because they are clearly visible and possess beautiful colors, we are deceived by them. But the Buddha has demonstrated the truth. In this long saṃsāric journey of ours, what is chief, what precedes—what assists our actions in becoming good or bad—is this mind that arises within us.

"*Mano pubbaṅgamā dhammā — manoseṭṭhā manomayā*." Not only that, they are created by that very mind. Now, according to this story, this becomes extremely clear. Maṭṭakuṇḍalī's celestial body was created by the mind itself. It was visible to humans. It became apparent to the beings present at that time that in his final moments, the Brahmin's son had obtained such a celestial existence with golden ornaments merely by clarifying his mind towards the Buddha. That is why, through that very faith (*saddhā*), other necessary Dhamma qualities accumulated in his mind, and he obtained the realization of the stages of awakening. Therefore, within this narrative, which we might think of as simple, extremely valuable and deep Dhamma is contained.

Thus, creating an opening in the mind at each moment. This is what is done through the practice of virtues such as *sīla*. Purifying the mind by way of substitution of opposites (*tadaṅga*), or in other words, clarifying it. There are three stages of effort in developing this. It is mentioned in the Dhamma as *tadaṅga* (substitution of opposites), *vikkhambhana* (suppression), and *samuccheda* (eradication). Now, what is done through virtue—in observing those training rules—is that at each moment, one presents a wholesome thought and drives away the unwholesome. Next, a slightly more established and even more developed stage than that is concentration (*samādhi*). This too, in this manner, if one develops meditation through *Buddhānussati* etc., and controls

the wandering mind, the mind that runs after various objects, through a suitable meditation subject—such as the phrase "may all beings be well and happy" or through a meditation subject like "Buddho" or "Araham"—after some time, the mind settles down. This settling down is called concentration (*samādhi*). The phenomena that darken the mind are referred to in the Dhamma as hindrances (*nīvaraṇas*). Sensual thoughts, angry thoughts, sloth and torpor, and various other regrets, restlessness, and doubt—when all these are suppressed, just as mud settles and the water in a lake becomes clear, a clarified state of mind arises. That is called concentration (*samādhi*). This too is a state one can experience through a meditation subject; it is a very special state where the mind's clarity is far greater than before.

Next, finally, the stage that goes even deeper is called eradication (*samuccheda*). Deep within the mind lie the grave defilements known as *anusaya* (underlying tendencies) carried along throughout Samsāra. They remain suppressed. To dry them up, to eliminate them, one must develop wisdom (*paññā*). Contemplating this entire body, this life, in terms of *anicca* (impermanent), *dukkha* (suffering), and *anattā* (not-self), and developing insight (*vipassanā*), at a certain point the mind becomes illuminated. It is illuminated by wisdom. The phenomena that support this, as stated in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, are mindfulness and clear comprehension (*sati-sampajañña*), the development of mindfulness, and *yoniso manasikāra* (wise attention). Contemplating in that manner and developing meditation so that wisdom grows, developing the three characteristics of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*, then at the moment of realizing the stages of awakening, through insight-wisdom, one is able to generate from within the mind itself the power to destroy even the bottom-most layer of those unwholesome defilements that we have carried along throughout Samsāra.

Therefore, *sīla*, *samādhi*, and *paññā* (virtue, concentration, and wisdom) are indeed the Dispensation (*Sāsana*); this is what belongs to us. Many people explain the Buddha Dispensation in various ways. But the Buddha Dispensation is in fact the cultivation of *sīla*, *samādhi*, and *paññā* within one's own mind-stream. What supports this, the first necessary factor, is our understanding of the value of this mind of ours—that the mind precedes everything, that the mind is supreme, and that these are created by the mind. Regarding those celestial existences, it is extremely obvious how they are created by the mind itself. Let alone that, though we do not think about it daily, let us consider a potter who makes something like a pot; he molds the pot from that lump of clay according to a certain mental image or plan of the pot. Likewise, if someone has manufactured anything that lies before us, the perception regarding that manufacturing arises first in the mind. A plan arises. It is the same when building

a building. Where did this plan arise? In the mind. After it emerges as a form supported by the four great elements (*cattāro mahābhūtā*)—earth, water, fire, and wind—then people are deceived by it. Humans think, "This is the great thing." But many do not contemplate the plan underlying it. What the Buddha did was remind the world of this very fact. It is through that itself that one can escape from Samsāra. Therefore, one must contemplate with wisdom. This is what is called right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*). Wrong view (*micchā-diṭṭhi*) means giving priority to unsuitable things, inappropriate things, or incorrect things. Right view, the correct vision, means bringing to the surface those Dhamma qualities that help us escape from the *Dukkha* of Samsāra, in the manner declared by the Buddha.

Therefore, we must reflect according to this Dhamma verse. We must reflect on our own lives—regardless of age. "How am I leading my life? Is it according to what the world says, in the way society goes, or is it in the way shown by the Buddha?" Reflecting in this manner, one must prepare a plan necessary for daily life. Within this plan, there must be a place for virtue (*sīla*). There must be a place for concentration (*samādhi*). There must be a place for wisdom (*paññā*). A 'place' means understanding their values and spending one's daily life in a manner that brings them to the surface. Just now, you undertook the *ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla* (precepts with livelihood as the eighth). Through that, you, devout friends, can free the mind by way of substitution of opposites (*tadaṅga*). Like the archer splitting the horsehair by the flash of lightning, during those small, brief moments when unwholesome thoughts arise—when thoughts of committing a sin occur—you bring forward your virtue and drive them away. Next, if someone has developed the power of concentration, they can experience the clarity, serenity, and light of their mind for an even longer period. Then, through the realization of the stages of awakening—the realization of Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship—if someone develops wisdom and insight-knowledges (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*) and obtains liberation from Samsāra, they are able to experience the most valuable state in the world, the most purified state of their mind.

Therefore, you must think of utilizing this Dispensation of the fully Awakened One, utilizing the human existence we have obtained. This is something extremely rare; even deities sometimes say that this human existence, this human world, is the best place to realize Nibbāna. Though it is a brief, short period of time, if we utilize this period correctly, this human mind can be elevated to the highest state. That is why Buddhas are born only in the human world. That is why a Buddha appears only in the human world. Thinking in that manner, one must utilize the opportunity obtained. From every Dhamma sermon, one must extract

some example for one's life. Regarding the defilements, the *kilesas* that arise in the mind, one must consider them as dark and, in order to banish them, develop those wholesome phenomena called *sukka-dhamma* within the mind—generosity, loving-kindness, wisdom, and the realization of the Dhamma. At this moment, even through listening to the Dhamma, one can clarify the mind. For, through the Dhamma we see the Buddha; when listening to the Dhamma, the doubts and anxieties in one's mind are removed, hesitations disappear, and a clarity of mind arises. Clarity of mind is extremely necessary. It is through that alone that the true nature of the world is seen. When the mind is darkened, when it is darkened by delusion, the true nature is not visible. Consequently, one's words become wrong, and both words and actions incline towards the unwholesome, towards sin. Therefore, this Saṃsāra is generally a journey heavily inclined towards defilements, heavily inclined towards darkness. To step away from this, one must generate a great power.

In fact, when we consider the meanings of the two words *kusala* and *akusala*: *kusala* means being skillful, and *akusala* means being unskillful. In this saṃsāric journey, inclining towards hell is unskillfulness, while inclining towards happy destinations is skillfulness. Furthermore, having to continue in this Saṃsāra is unskillfulness, while quickly putting an end to saṃsāric *Dukkha* is skillfulness. When we contemplate in this way, what we call mundane and supramundane *kusala*—this *kusala* means skillfulness, skillfulness. This skillfulness is not something that can be achieved all at once like that archer. This must be developed over a long period. Therefore, from today itself, one must strive at every moment, without thinking "there is no time." In daily life, people say they have no time. But there is a lot of time that everyone wastes. This can be clearly recognized—though perhaps not heard in Dhamma sermons, there is a word often heard in society: "rastiyādu venavā" (loitering or wasting time / being held up). Wasting time in this way is a moment when rust accumulates on the mind, a moment when the mind becomes dark. In daily life, we often hear of such moments of being held up: "I went to such-and-such an office and got held up there." Being held up on the road. This is an extremely good opportunity to bring forward one's accustomed meditation subject. Let us think of the Buddha-gem—like taking out a gem from one's pocket and looking at it with joy—in such moments, taking out that Buddha-gem, the supreme gem in the world spoken of here, in a way invisible to others (not because they will steal it, as it is of no use to them anyway), but bringing up that Buddha-gem: "Buddho, Buddho, Buddho" or "Arahaṃ, Arahaṃ, Arahaṃ." Then, they have utilized that time spent waiting. Or else, "may all beings be well and happy"—some meditation subject they have taken up. Or else, focusing on one's inhalation and exhalation, which is called mindfulness of breathing (*ānāpānasati*). If those moments of being held up or

wasted time are utilized, that person, without even realizing it, becomes a meditator. In the end, almost without realizing it—we say "without even realizing it" because the way this mind functions is so wondrous—if the mind has matured, even in unexpected moments, they might even realize the stages of awakening.

Sometimes, the saying that in the past, while the Buddha was preaching the Dhamma, someone became an Arahant or a Stream-enterer right during the sermon, is misunderstood by intellectualized scholars of this era. They think, "We can also do it that way." It was only those minds that had practiced and trained in those virtues under Buddhas or within Dispensations for a long period in Saṃsāra, elevating them to a high level so that only a tiny spark was needed, that were able to realize the stages of awakening so quickly. One must not think that everyone is like that. But the lesson we must draw from it is: if someone wishes to obtain such a state in a brief moment, it must be practiced over a long period. It must be trained. One must strive to create opportunities for that within one's own life.

Today, on this valuable Uposatha day, you, devout friends, undertook the valuable *ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla*. If it is not treated as a mere ritual, but by reflecting on each precept—this virtue (*sīla*) is a certain code of conduct regarding the control of body and speech. To protect it, the mind must assist. The mind assists precisely through that mind of abstinence, described as the *virati-cetasika*. One must bring forward the thought of abstaining from the things mentioned. Saying "do not do these things" is easier. That is why the Buddha has used the word *veramaṇī* (abstaining) in these virtues. Scholars sometimes think there is nothing in this. This is precisely where something exists. Therefore, regarding this *ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla*—if one directs the mind well at the moment of undertaking this virtue, that moment too is an instance where a great opening occurs in the mind. One establishes a determination in the mind: "I have done such-and-such things. Hereafter, I will not do them." This is a great thing. If that determination is made in the morning, and if one is able to protect it throughout the day, that person will experience a clarity, peacefulness, and joy in the mind by evening. Such is virtue. Next, likewise, if in daily life one has practiced some meditation subject—without saying it is difficult or there is no time—utilizing free moments, moments of relaxation, bringing up that meditation subject and developing the mind, then that person, without even realizing it, grows in concentration (*samādhi*). At some point, the mind might even enter absorption (*jhāna*). After working hard, when one lies down contemplating that meditation subject on the bed, sometimes absorption (*jhāna*) can be attained.

That was how lay disciples in the past, like Nakulamātā, Nakulapitā, Citta the householder, Anāthapiṇḍika, and others, obtained such high states. The Buddhist

laymen and laywomen of the Buddha's time did not lead lives completely immersed and drowned in matters of money. Being inclined towards the Dhamma, and somehow finding time for the Dhamma, they were able to develop concentration in that manner. Next, what is even more valuable is using that concentration as an aid to understand the true nature of the world—*anicca* (impermanent), *dukkha* (suffering), and *anattā* (not-self)—through the very events that happen in daily life. Indeed, every event that occurs in the world can be placed within these three aspects of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*. These are the three characteristics. These three characteristics can be seen everywhere, wherever one looks. But proper contemplation must be present. There must be right vision, which is called *yoniso manasikāra*. For a person with right vision, the streams, brooks, and rivers flowing in this world, the fruits and flowers falling from these trees—through all these things, they can develop insight (*vipassanā*). They can see the three characteristics of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*. In that manner, one must contemplate well on how to direct one's mind in daily life. Without putting this off saying "I cannot do it," if one plans to clarify the mind only in old age or at the near-death moment to go to a celestial world like Maṭṭakuṇālī, then this Dhamma sermon has been misunderstood. It has been understood in a distorted way. That is not how one should think. There is a saying in the world: "If so much can be gained from that, how much more can be gained from this?" In that manner, if so much can be achieved through the mind in a brief moment, what cannot be accomplished once it is well developed?—thus one must contemplate.

Contemplating thus, today, through the undertaking of precepts, and then through clarifying the mind towards the Triple Gem by listening to this Dhamma, you have made a beginning in walking upon the path of Dhamma expressed in this verse. You must make the aspiration: "May this store of merit generated through this, by cultivating and developing within our mind-stream those spiritual faculties (*indriya*) and powers (*bala*) of *saddhā* (faith), *viriya* (energy), *sati* (mindfulness), *samādhi* (concentration), and *paññā* (wisdom) that aid in reaching Nibbāna, enable us to realize this sublime Dhamma of Nibbāna, if possible in this very life, through the realization of the stages of awakening—Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship—and being freed from all saṃsāric *Dukkha* of *jāti* (birth), *jarāmaraṇa* (aging and death), sickness, and the like, may we be peaceful in the deathless, great Nibbāna—may we obtain the ability, strength, and power for this."

Likewise, to whatever extent there is a host of right-viewed deities and Brahmas who protect the Dispensation, and similarly, whatever deities and spirits who reside in this sacred place who desire merit and desire Nibbāna—may all of them rejoice in this merit of our Dhamma preaching and Dhamma listening, and

rejoicing, may they all realize the sublime, deathless, great Nibbāna through a Bodhi of their aspiration. Furthermore, whatever departed relatives there may be who have passed away, and not only them, but from the Avīci hell to the Akanisṭha heaven, whatever beings there are who desire merit and desire Nibbāna—may all of them rejoice in our merit of Dhamma preaching and Dhamma listening, and being freed from their respective miserable states, and walking on the path of Dhamma, may they be peaceful in the sublime, deathless, great Nibbāna as quickly as possible. Now, let us transfer merit by reciting the verses in this manner.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”